

Rath RPG

Homebrew Guide

Erratic Eye Games

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Homebrew Guide

Creating custom aptitudes and magic Circles

This guide is for GMs and experienced players who want to expand Rath with their own content. If you just want to build a character, see the **Players Handbook** instead.

Note: All starter content is complete and balanced—you don't need to create anything custom to have a full-featured game.

Introduction

This guide explains how to create new aptitudes and Circles of Magic that fit seamlessly into Rath. Use these tools to:

- Design aptitudes that match your character concepts
- Create new Circles of Magic with unique themes
- Maintain balance with existing content
- Extend the system for your campaign world

Who should use this guide: - GMs wanting to offer custom options to players - Players working with their GM to realize unique concepts - Designers wanting to understand the system's philosophy

When to create custom content: - You have a character concept that existing aptitudes don't support - You want a magic theme not covered by existing Circles - Your campaign world needs setting-specific abilities - You're adapting content from other systems

When NOT to create custom content: - Just starting with the system (use existing content first) - During character creation at session 1 (too much to learn) - Without GM approval and collaboration - To "fix" perceived balance issues (discuss with GM first)

Part 1: Creating Aptitudes

Aptitudes are the mechanical abilities that define what your character can do. They should be **generally useful** without being **overpowered**.

Aptitude Design Philosophy

Aptitudes should:

- Be **useful** - Clear purpose and application in most sessions
- Have **conditions or limitations** - Prevent them from being overpowered
- Fit a **theme** - Someone of a particular profession or species would have it
- Scale with **level** when appropriate - Use "L times per long rest" for abilities that get more powerful

Avoid:

- Flat, unconditional bonuses (like “+1 to hit on all attacks”)
- Abilities without costs or triggers
- Overly complex mechanics that slow play
- Abilities that make other characters feel useless

Types of Aptitudes

Skill Aptitudes

Learned abilities that any character could potentially train in:

- **Combat skills** - Fighting techniques, weapon mastery, tactical abilities
- **Magic** - Spellcasting, magical enhancement, arcane knowledge
- **Exploration** - Stealth, survival, navigation, trap handling
- **Social** - Persuasion, intimidation, diplomacy, leadership
- **Knowledge** - Lore, languages, scholarly pursuits
- **Crafting** - Item creation, repair, modification

Key principle: Any dedicated student could theoretically learn these through training.

Inherent Aptitudes

Innate traits tied to a character’s physical nature or magical essence:

- **Sensory** - Enhanced senses, unusual perception abilities
- **Physical/Anatomical** - Natural weapons, armor, unusual body parts
- **Movement** - Flight, climbing, swimming, teleportation
- **Combat** - Natural fighting abilities, pack tactics, regeneration
- **Magical/Mystical** - Innate magic resistance, supernatural knowledge
- **Constructed** - Abilities for artificial or magical beings

Key principle: These define what a character IS, not what they’ve learned.

Design Guidelines for Skill Aptitudes

Combat Aptitudes

Good triggers and conditions:

- “When you reduce enemy to 0 HP” (Cleave)
- “When fighting 1-on-1” (Duelist)
- “When enemy misses you” (Riposte)
- “L times per long rest” (Mighty Blow)
- “Once per combat” (Whirlwind Strike)

Examples to follow:

- **Cleave:** Simple trigger (reduce to 0 HP), clear benefit (free attack), doesn’t slow combat
- **Duelist:** Conditional advantage (1-on-1 only) + expanded crit range (18-20)
- **Shield Bash:** Active ability with cost (use action, requires shield), provides control (stun)

Why these work: - Clear triggers that are easy to track - Meaningful but not overwhelming benefits - Reward specific playstyles without dominating - Create interesting tactical decisions

Avoid:

- Unconditional bonuses without triggers (boring, unbalanced)
- Abilities that trigger too frequently (every attack becomes a chore)
- Complex calculations that slow combat (d20+STR+proficiency+situation-bonus-terrain...)
- “Passive +X to everything” abilities (make other characters feel worse)

Magic Aptitudes

Magic aptitudes should enhance spellcasting without overshadowing the Circle system:

Good patterns:

- Modify spell mechanics (Spell Twister, Metamagic)
- Provide spell recovery (Arcane Recovery)
- Enhance specific casting styles (Spellblade, Ritual Caster)
- Offer defensive options (Spellshield, Counterspell)

Examples:

- **Spell Twister:** Once/long rest, change one scaling parameter without increasing DC (limited uses, GM approval required)
- **Metamagic:** L times/long rest, cast silently or without gestures (scales with level, situational benefit)
- **Blood Magic:** Take HP equal to DC to auto-succeed (high cost, desperate option)

Why these work: - Expand what casters can do WITHOUT giving them more spells - Create meaningful choices (when to use limited abilities) - Support different casting styles (ritual, combat, subtle) - Have costs or limitations

Avoid: - “Cast one extra spell per day” (just makes casters better at everything) - Reducing spell DCs without cost (breaks the scaling system) - Abilities that eliminate spell weaknesses (armor doesn’t hinder you) - Making all Circles equally good at everything (homogenizes magic)

Exploration Aptitudes

Exploration aptitudes should create interesting choices and enable specific playstyles:

Good patterns:

- Advantage on specific types of tests (Move Silently and Unseen, Wild Walker)
- Special abilities once per rest period (Shadow Step, Escape Artist)
- Passive benefits that enhance role (Dungeon Sense, Cartographer)
- Companion creatures that add options (Hunting Dog, Familiar)

Consider:

- Does this enable a specific archetype? (thief, scout, tracker)
- Does it create interesting decisions? (when to use limited abilities)
- Is it useful frequently enough? (avoid overly situational)

Examples:

- **Wild Walker:** Advantage in wilderness (defines clear niche)
- **Shadow Step:** Once/long rest teleport (strong but limited)
- **Cartographer:** Auto-map areas (always useful, never overpowered)

Why these work: - Define clear niches (you're THE wilderness person) - Useful regularly but not overwhelming - Create opportunities for clever play - Make exploration more interesting

Avoid: - "You can't fail at X" (removes challenge) - Too broad advantages (advantage on ALL tests) - Abilities that only work in one specific scenario per campaign - Replacements for player skill (auto-solve all puzzles)

Social Aptitudes

Social aptitudes should enhance roleplay without replacing it:

Good patterns:

- Advantage on specific social tests (Silver Tongue)
- Once per encounter abilities (Fast Talk)
- Conditional bonuses (Intimidating Presence)
- Information gathering (Read Tells, Network)

Important:

- Should enhance roleplay, not replace it
- Should have reasonable limitations
- Should fit character archetype

Examples:

- **Silver Tongue:** Advantage to negotiate (but not mind control)
- **Fast Talk:** Reroll one failed CHA test (limited, clutch ability)
- **Network:** Know someone useful in each location (creates story hooks)

Why these work: - Player still has to describe WHAT they say - Dice help when it matters, don't auto-win - Create story opportunities - Reward social character builds

Avoid: - Mind control or compulsion effects as aptitudes (that's magic) - Automatic success on all social tests (boring) - Abilities that short-circuit entire social encounters - Making other players feel like they shouldn't talk

Design Guidelines for Inherent Aptitudes

Inherent aptitudes define what a character IS rather than what they've learned.

Physical/Anatomical Traits

Consider:

- How does this change the character's form?
- What are the trade-offs? (Natural Armor prevents manufactured armor)
- Is it always-on or situational?

Examples:

- **Natural Weapons:** 1d6+STR damage (comparable to weapons, always available)
- **Natural Armor:** +2 AC but can't wear manufactured armor (trade-off)
- **Demon Tail:** Can hold things but can't wield weapon (interesting limitation)

Why these work: - Clear mechanical benefits - Balanced by trade-offs or limitations - Create interesting character concepts - Always relevant (define your form)

Avoid: - "Natural weapons AND armor AND claws AND..." (too much) - No trade-offs (just better than everyone) - Purely cosmetic traits masquerading as aptitudes - Body parts that never matter in play

Movement Traits

Consider:

- How does this change exploration and combat?
- What are the limitations? (can't use while hands full)
- Is it magical or physical?

Examples:

- **Leathery Wings:** Can't fly but can glide (limited benefit, interesting)
- **Spider Climb:** Climb at half speed, hands must be free (useful, balanced)
- **Forest Walk:** Step into trees (magical, thematic, limited by environment)

Why these work: - Solve specific movement challenges - Have clear limitations (not just "better") - Create tactical options in combat - Enable interesting exploration

Avoid: - Unlimited teleportation (breaks encounters) - Flight with no restrictions (trivializes many challenges) - Speed bonuses without trade-offs (+10 ft all the time is boring) - Movement that makes other characters irrelevant

Magical/Mystical Traits

Consider:

- How does this reflect the character's nature?
- Does it create interesting story opportunities?
- Is it too powerful for always-on?

Examples:

- **Magic Resistance:** Advantage vs spells (strong but passive)
- **Soulspell:** Absorb spell without slot but lose original (interesting trade-off)
- **Innate Spellcasting:** Cast one spell L times/long rest (limited but reliable)

Why these work: - Create unique magical identities - Generate story hooks (why are you like this?) - Balanced by limitations or costs - Interact interestingly with the magic system

Avoid: - Immunity to entire damage types (unless very narrow) - Always-on spell effects with no cost (that's Circle of Magic) - Abilities that let you "cheat" the magic system - Generic magical bonuses (+1 to all magic tests)

Balancing Aptitudes

Power Level Guidelines

Weak Aptitudes (rarely useful or very limited):

- Passive +1 bonus in specific rare situations
- Ability usable once per week
- Very situational benefit that rarely applies
- Benefits that are purely cosmetic

Example weak aptitude: “**Lucky Coin:** Once per month, you can flip a coin and call it for +1 on your next test.”

Why it's weak: Too limited (once per month), too small benefit (+1), too unreliable (coin flip).

Moderate Aptitudes (the target):

- Advantage on specific types of tests
- Ability usable L times per long rest
- Once per combat abilities
- Always-on benefits with trade-offs

Example moderate aptitudes: - **Cleave:** Free attack when you drop enemy (common trigger, useful benefit) - **Wild Walker:** Advantage in wilderness (niche but substantial) - **Shadow Step:** Teleport once per long rest (powerful but limited)

Why they're moderate: Useful regularly, meaningful benefits, clear limitations or triggers.

Strong Aptitudes (risk of overshadowing):

- Unconditional advantage on common tests
- Abilities usable every round
- Large bonuses without conditions
- Multiple benefits in one aptitude

Example strong aptitude: “**Master Warrior:** +2 to all attack rolls, advantage on all STR tests, and +2 AC.”

Why it's too strong: No conditions, multiple benefits, always active, makes combat characters strictly better.

Most aptitudes should be Moderate. A character with 2 Moderate aptitudes feels capable without being overpowered.

Testing Your Aptitude

Ask yourself:

1. **Is it generally useful?** If it only applies in one specific scenario per session, it's too narrow
2. **Does it have appropriate limitations?** No unlimited power without costs or conditions
3. **Does it fit a clear theme?** What profession or species would have this? Why?
4. **Does it scale appropriately?** Should it use “L times per long rest” to grow with character?
5. **Would I be excited to choose this?** If not, it needs more interesting benefits or better

flavor

Compare to existing aptitudes:

- Is it weaker or stronger than similar aptitudes?
- Does it overlap too much with another aptitude?
- Does it create interesting decisions, or is it just “always use this”?
- Would you feel bad if another player took this instead of you?

Playtest questions:

- Did it come up in most sessions?
- Did it create interesting moments or just passive benefits?
- Did other players feel overshadowed?
- Was it too complicated to remember/use?

Example: Creating a New Aptitude

Let's walk through creating a new aptitude from concept to final version.

Concept: An aptitude for a character who's a master of thrown weapons

First Draft

“Thrown Weapon Master: Advantage on all thrown weapon attacks”

Problems: - Too simple and unconditional - Doesn't create interesting decisions - Just a flat bonus with no flavor - Boring to use (always the same)

Second Draft

“Thrown Weapon Master: After hitting with a thrown weapon, your next thrown weapon attack this combat has advantage. You can draw thrown weapons as a free action.”

Why this is better: - Creates a conditional benefit (must hit first) - Rewards consecutive throws (builds momentum) - Includes utility benefit (quick draw) - Fits the archetype without being overpowered

Remaining issues: - Lacks flavor - Doesn't scale with level - Might be too weak (only one advantage per hit)

Final Version

“Thrown Weapon Master: After hitting with a thrown weapon, your next thrown weapon attack this combat has advantage. Additionally, you can draw thrown weapons as a free action, and you always seem to have one more throwing knife than anyone expects.”

Why the final version works: - Clear mechanical benefit (conditional advantage) - Interesting decision point (when to throw vs melee) - Utility benefit (quick draw) - Narrative flavor (the last sentence) - Comparable to other combat aptitudes - Opens up thrown weapon as viable playstyle

Could also add scaling: “L times per long rest, you can throw a weapon with such force it deals +1d6 damage.”

Aptitude Templates

Use these templates as starting points for creating new aptitudes:

Combat Aptitude Template

[Name]: When [trigger condition], [benefit]. [Optional: Frequency limitation]

Examples: - **Cleave:** When you reduce enemy to 0 HP, free attack on another enemy in close range - **Mighty Blow:** L times/long rest, declare before attack. If hit, roll damage twice, take higher

Magic Aptitude Template

[Name]: [Frequency], [spell-related benefit or modification]. [Optional: Limitation or cost]

Examples: - **Spell Twister:** Once/long rest, change one scaling parameter without increasing DC (GM approval) - **Blood Magic:** Cast spell: take HP = DC to auto-succeed (still burns spell)

Exploration Aptitude Template

[Name]: Advantage on [specific type of test]. [Optional: Additional benefit in niche]

Examples: - **Wild Walker:** Advantage to track/hunt/forage/navigate in natural wilderness - **Dungeon Sense:** Advantage to detect traps, secret doors, unusual construction. Can tell depth underground

Social Aptitude Template

[Name]: Advantage on [social stat] to [specific social goal]. [Optional: Limitation]

Examples: - **Silver Tongue:** Advantage on CHA to negotiate, improve reactions, convince risk (not against core interests) - **Intimidating Presence:** Advantage to intimidate smaller creatures or with fewer HD than your level

Part 2: Creating Circles of Magic

Circles define what type of magic a caster can perform. Each Circle provides a theme and spell framework.

Circle Design Philosophy

Circles should:

- Have a **clear theme** that's easy to explain in one sentence

- Provide **versatile options** for different situations
- Allow for **creative problem-solving**
- Scale appropriately with the spell level system

Avoid:

- Circles that only do one thing (too narrow)
- Themes that overlap too much with existing Circles (redundant)
- Concepts that are too narrow or too broad (hard to use)
- Complexity that makes spellcasting tedious

Choosing Your Theme

Strong Themes

Transmutation - Alteration of matter and form

- Clear concept: change things
- Versatile: works on objects, creatures, materials
- Scalable: small changes to dramatic transformations
- Example spells: Stoneflesh, Shrink/Enlarge, Liquid Form

Conjuration - Creation and summoning

- Clear concept: bring things into existence
- Versatile: creatures, objects, elements
- Scalable: temporary to permanent, small to large
- Example spells: Conjure Flame, Summon Swarm, Fog Cloud

Elementalism - Fire, water, air, earth

- Clear concept: primal forces
- Versatile: damage, control, utility
- Scalable: small effects to devastating forces
- Example spells: Flame Jet, Stone Grasp, Whispering Wind

Why these work: - Instantly understandable theme - Can handle combat, exploration, and social situations - Many possible spells within theme - Distinct from each other

Weak Themes (and how to fix them)

“Weather Magic” - Too narrow

- Problem: Only works outdoors, limited spell variety
- Fix: Broaden to “Nature” (includes plants, animals, weather)
- Or: Add to Elementalism (weather is air and water)

“Attack Magic” - Too general

- Problem: No clear identity, overlaps with everything
- Fix: Specify element or method (Elementalism for elemental damage)
- Or: Focus on specific attack style (Necromancy for death/decay)

“Reality Warping” - Too vague

- Problem: Could mean anything, no clear boundaries
- Fix: Focus on specific aspect (Fate for probability, Illusion for perception, Transmutation for matter)

“Healing Magic” - Too narrow

- Problem: Only one function, not versatile enough
- Fix: Broaden to “Holy” (healing + turn undead + blessings)
- Or: Part of divine/nature magic, not standalone Circle

Creating Base Level Spells

Base level spells are the foundation of your Circle. They should be **useful** and **scalable**.

The Framework

Every base spell needs:

1. **Effect** - What does it do?
2. **Target/Area** - What does it affect? (usually 1 target or 10 ft area)
3. **Range** - How far can you cast it? (usually 30 ft or touch)
4. **Duration** - How long does it last? (1 round for combat, 1 turn for exploration)

Spell Creation Process

Step 1: Start with the concept

“I want to summon a demon to fight for me”

Step 2: Find the appropriate base level

A demon is person-sized and powerful. That’s too much for base level.

Analysis: - Size: Person-sized creatures are higher-level summons - Power: Combat-effective creatures need to be limited - Duration: Permanent summons are very high-level

Step 3: Scale down to base level

- **Size:** Person → Item (a small imp instead of a demon)
- **Duration:** Permanent → 1 round (temporary summoning)
- **Number:** Many → 1 (single creature)
- **Power:** Full stats → Simple commands, basic attacks

Step 4: Write the base spell

Summon Imp - Summon 1 imp (item-sized) to obey your commands for 1 round

Step 5: Identify what can scale

- **Size:** Item → Object → Person (imp → demon → greater demon)
- **Duration:** 1 round → 3 rounds → 1 turn → 1 hour
- **Number:** 1 → 2 → 3 → 5 imps
- **Power:** Basic commands → Complex tactics → Independent action

Result: A useful base spell that can scale to meet different needs.

Scaling Guidelines

Each enhancement should add roughly the same power level:

Damage spells: - +1d to damage = +1 DC - ×2 area = +1 DC - +10 ft range = +1 DC

Duration spells: - +1 round/turn/hour/day = +1 DC (choose appropriate to spell)

Target spells: - +1 target = +1 DC - Bigger target size = +2 DC per size category

Complexity: - Simple → Moderate = +1 DC - Moderate → Complex = +2 DC

Examples:

Base: Conjure Flame - 10 ft fireball, 1d4 fire damage (DC 12) - 2d4 damage → DC 13 (+1 enhancement) - 20 ft fireball → DC 13 (+1 enhancement) - 2d4 damage, 20 ft → DC 14 (+2 enhancements)

Base: Stoneflesh - +1 AC for 1 round (DC 12) - +2 AC for 1 round → DC 13 (+1 enhancement) - +1 AC for 3 rounds → DC 14 (+2 enhancements) - +2 AC for 3 rounds → DC 15 (+3 enhancements)

Creating 8 Spells for Your Circle

Each Circle should have 8 example spells that showcase different aspects of the theme.

The Eight Spell Framework

1. **Basic Damage/Attack** - Direct harm or obstacle
2. **Control/Hinder** - Slow, restrain, or debuff enemies
3. **Utility/Creation** - Create useful objects or effects
4. **Enhancement** - Buff allies or self
5. **Detection/Information** - Learn things or sense hidden
6. **Movement/Escape** - Mobility or defensive repositioning
7. **Area Effect** - Affect multiple targets or large area
8. **Unique/Signature** - Something special to this Circle

Why this framework: - Ensures versatility (combat + exploration + social) - Covers different playstyles - Makes Circle feel complete - Easy to reference during creation

Example: Circle of Transmutation

1. **Lightfoot** (Movement) - Ignore difficult terrain, move silently
2. **Stoneflesh** (Enhancement) - +1 AC
3. **Alter Object** (Utility) - Change material of objects
4. **Shrink/Enlarge** (Control) - Change size of creatures
5. **Mend** (Utility) - Repair broken items
6. **Animal Shape** (Enhancement) - Gain animal traits
7. **Purify Matter** (Utility) - Remove poison/disease/rot
8. **Liquid Form** (Unique) - Become fluid

Coverage checklist: - Combat options (Stoneflesh for defense, Shrink/Enlarge for control) - Exploration utility (Alter Object, Mend, Purify, Lightfoot) - Social/interesting (Animal Shape, Liquid Form) - Versatile at different scales (all can be enhanced)

Example: Creating a New Circle

Let's create a complete Circle from scratch.

Circle of Sound

Theme: Manipulation of sound, vibration, and resonance

Core concept: Control sound waves for communication, offense, defense, and exploration

Why this theme works: - Clear, understandable concept - Versatile (combat, exploration, social) - Distinct from existing Circles - Lots of creative spell possibilities

Step 1: Brainstorm spell concepts

- Create loud noise to distract
- Silence an area
- Use sound as a weapon
- Amplify or dampen sounds
- Communicate over distance
- Shatter objects with resonance
- Create echoes to map area
- Throw voice

Step 2: Create 8 base level spells

1. **Thunderclap** (Damage)
 - 10 ft burst of sound, 1d4 damage
 - Enhancements: +1d4, ×2 area, +10 ft range
2. **Silence** (Control)
 - 10 ft area of silence for 1 round
 - Enhancements: ×2 area, +1 round
3. **Amplify Voice** (Utility)
 - Your voice carries to far distance (60 ft) for 1 turn
 - Enhancements: +60 ft, +1 turn, affect sounds beyond voice
4. **Muffle Steps** (Enhancement)
 - One creature moves silently for 1 turn
 - Enhancements: +1 target, +1 turn
5. **Echo Sense** (Detection)
 - Send out soundwave to map near area (30 ft) through walls, 1 round
 - Enhancements: +30 ft, +1 round, more detail
6. **Sonic Burst** (Area)
 - Push creatures 10 ft in 10 ft cone with sound
 - Enhancements: +10 ft distance, ×2 area, 1d4 damage
7. **Shatter** (Damage)
 - Item-sized brittle object shatters (glass, pottery, thin wood)

- Enhancements: increase size, affect tougher materials

8. **Ventriloquism** (Unique)

- Project your voice to near range point (30 ft) for 1 round
- Enhancements: +30 ft, +1 round, multiple voices

Step 3: Verify coverage

- Damage (Thunderclap, Shatter)
- Control (Silence, Sonic Burst)
- Utility (Amplify Voice, Ventriloquism)
- Enhancement (Muffle Steps)
- Detection (Echo Sense)
- Variety of situations (combat, stealth, exploration, social)
- Scalable options (all can be enhanced)

Analysis: - **Combat:** Thunderclap for damage, Sonic Burst for area control, Silence to counter casters - **Exploration:** Echo Sense for mapping, Muffle Steps for stealth, Shatter for breaking obstacles - **Social:** Amplify Voice for speeches/intimidation, Ventriloquism for deception/distraction - **Unique flavor:** All spells feel thematically connected to sound

Result: A complete, balanced Circle that's distinct from existing options.

Advanced Spell Creation

Complex Spell Scaling

Some spells scale in multiple ways:

Summon Elemental - Base: Summon 1 item-sized elemental for 1 round - Can scale: size, duration, number, elemental type

Example scalings: - DC 13: Summon 1 item-sized elemental for 2 rounds (+1 duration) - DC 14: Summon 1 object-sized elemental for 1 round (+2 size categories) - DC 16: Summon 3 item-sized elementals for 1 round (+2 number) - DC 18: Summon 1 person-sized elemental for 3 rounds (+3 size, +2 duration)

Why allow multiple scaling: - Gives caster flexibility - Same spell useful at different levels
- Rewards system mastery - Creates interesting choices

Spells with Saves

Some spells require targets to make saves:

Base pattern: - Target makes [STAT] test vs DC 12 - Each enhancement to DC = +1 spell DC

Example: Charm Person - Base: Target within 30 ft makes WIS test DC 12 or becomes friendly for 1 turn - +1 DC: WIS test DC 13 (+1 enhancement) - +1 turn: Lasts 2 turns (+1 enhancement) - +1 target: Affects 2 targets (+1 enhancement)

Total cost for DC 13, 2 turns, 2 targets = DC 15 spell (3 enhancements)

Design notes: - Base save DC always 12 (consistent) - Increasing save DC costs same as

other enhancements - Makes spells work on tougher enemies at higher cost

Permanent Effects

Permanent effects are high level by nature:

Guidelines: - Small permanent changes: DC 15-18 (permanent light on object, minor transformation) - Significant permanent changes: DC 18-21 (create permanent servant, major transformation) - Always allow ritual casting to reduce DC - Consider requiring rare materials or long casting times

Example: Permanent Familiar from Circle of Conjuration - Base: Call Familiar (small creature, 1 hour) - DC 12 - Make permanent: +6 DC - Total: DC 18 or DC 12 with 6 turns of ritual

Why permanent effects are expensive: - Change game world permanently - Can create permanent resources - Could be abused if too cheap - Should feel like major accomplishments

Testing Your Circle

Balance Checklist

Versatility: - ☐ Combat options (damage or control) - ☐ Exploration utility (detection, movement, or manipulation) - ☐ Social potential (communication, enhancement, or illusion)

Power Level: - ☐ Base damage comparable to other Circles (1d4-1d6 for damage spells) - ☐ Duration comparable (1 round combat, 1 turn exploration) - ☐ Range reasonable (30 ft or touch for most)

Theme: - ☐ Every spell fits the Circle's concept - ☐ Spells feel distinct from other Circles - ☐ Theme is easy to explain in one sentence

Playability: - ☐ Spells create interesting decisions - ☐ Scaling is intuitive - ☐ No spells are strictly better than others at base level

Playtesting

Test these scenarios:

1. **Combat encounter:** Can the Circle contribute meaningfully?
2. **Dungeon exploration:** Does it provide useful options?
3. **Social situation:** Can it enhance roleplay?
4. **Problem-solving:** Does it enable creative solutions?

Red flags: - Circle only works in one type of situation - Spells are too similar to each other - Scaling feels arbitrary or confusing - Players confused about what the Circle does - One spell gets used 90% of the time

Green lights: - Players excited to try different spells - Creative uses emerge during play - Feels distinct from other Circles - Works at multiple character levels

Circle Templates

Use these templates as starting points for creating new Circles:

Template: Damage-Focused Circle

Theme: [Your damage type/method]

Example spells:

1. Direct damage (1d4-1d6 base)
2. Area damage (smaller damage or area at base)
3. Damage over time (DoT effect)
4. Enhanced weapon (add element to attacks)
5. Damage shield (hurt attackers)
6. Utility spell (non-damage, fits theme)
7. Control/debuff (weaken enemies)
8. Movement or defensive option

Use for: Elementalism variants, weapon magic, destruction

Examples: Fire magic, necrotic damage, radiant light

Template: Control-Focused Circle

Theme: [Your control method]

Example spells:

1. Single target immobilize/stun
2. Area slow/hinder
3. Force movement (push, pull)
4. Create barrier/obstacle
5. Debuff enemies
6. Remove control from others (dispel)
7. Utility/manipulation
8. Enhancement/protection

Use for: Mentalism, manipulation, terrain control

Examples: Mind control, ice/earth binding, gravity

Template: Utility-Focused Circle

Theme: [Your utility focus]

Example spells:

1. Create/summon useful item
2. Repair/modify object

3. Enhance item or creature
4. Detect/sense
5. Communicate
6. Movement utility
7. Environmental manipulation
8. Problem-solving spell

Use for: Artifice, conjuration, support magic

Examples: Creation magic, enhancement magic, detection

Part 3: Putting It All Together

Creating a Custom Class

A class is simply a combination of 2 aptitudes + keywords. Here's the full process:

Step 1: Concept

"I want to play a battle-mage who uses sound magic and fights with weapons"

Step 2: Choose or Create Aptitudes

Option A: Use existing aptitudes - Circle of Magic (Sound) - custom Circle - Swordspell (cast while wielding weapon) - existing aptitude

Option B: Create custom aptitude - Circle of Magic (Sound) - custom Circle - Sonic Blade - When you hit with melee weapon, can release sonic wave as free action: near range line, 1d4 damage, L times per long rest (custom aptitude)

Step 3: Assign Keywords

- Species: Human (2 Skill Aptitudes)
- Role: Sonic Knight or Sound Blade
- Background: (choose during play)

Step 4: Stats and Gear

Distribute stats focusing on INT (for magic) and STR or DEX (for combat)

Choose a one-handed weapon for Swordspell

Result

Sonic Knight (Human) - Aptitudes: Circle of Magic (Sound), Swordspell - Keywords: Human, Sonic Knight - Playstyle: Frontline combatant who weaves magic into weapon attacks

Example: Completely Custom Character

Concept

“A construct built as a siege weapon who’s gone rogue”

Aptitudes (2 Inherent = Demihuman)

1. **Reinforced Frame** (Inherent) - Advantage to resist knocked prone/pushed/grappled, count as one size larger
2. **Integrated Tool** (Inherent) - Built-in ballista (counts as crossbow, can’t be disarmed, no inventory slots)

Result: Demihuman Construct

Keywords

- Species: Siege Construct (custom, combines both aptitudes)
- Role: Artillery or Construct (could add role keyword later)
- Background: Rogue Weapon (adds now for flavor)

Stats

Distribute: 3, 2, 2, 1, 1, 0

Example distribution: - STR 2, DEX 1, INT 0, WIS 1, CON 3, CHA 2

Gear

- Weapon: Integrated ballista (d8, 3 slots worth but no slots used)
- Armor: No armor needed (rely on AC from DEX + future armor)
- Starting gear: Standard equipment

Result

Artillery - Siege Construct, Rogue Weapon

- HP: $10 + 2 = 12$
- AC: $10 + 1$ (DEX) = 11
- Inventory: $10 + 3 = 13$ slots
- Built-in weapon, very difficult to knock down or move, designed to be alone on battlefield

Narrative hooks: - Why did you go rogue? - Who built you and for what war? - How do you feel about your purpose? - What does freedom mean to a construct?

GM Approval and Balance

The Conversation

Creating custom content is a **collaborative process**:

Player: “I want to create an aptitude called Shadow Strike that lets me teleport to an enemy and attack with advantage.”

GM: “That’s interesting. How often can you use it?”

Player: “Maybe once per combat?”

GM: “That’s pretty strong since it’s both movement and advantage. What if it’s L times per long rest, so you start with just once but it scales?”

Player: “That works! And maybe I can only teleport to shadows?”

GM: “Perfect, that adds interesting decision-making and fits the theme.”

Result: Both player and GM happy with balanced, thematic ability.

Red Flags for GMs

Aptitude concerns: - No limitations or costs (“I want to teleport anywhere anytime”) - Strictly better than existing aptitudes (“Like Cleave but also +2 damage”) - Affects too many situations (“Advantage on all tests”) - Too complex to adjudicate quickly (requires 5 minutes of calculation)

Circle concerns: - Overlaps too much with existing Circles (“It’s like Transmutation but better”) - No clear theme or too narrow (“Magic of Tuesdays”) - Base spells too powerful or weak (1d10 damage at base, or just cosmetic effects) - Scaling doesn’t make sense (+1 DC for +10d6 damage)

Green Lights

Good signs: - Fits established patterns (similar to existing aptitudes/Circles) - Creates interesting decisions (when to use limited abilities) - Comparable power to existing options - Easy to understand and use - Enhances character concept without overshadowing others - Player excited about the theme, not just the power

Advancement and Growth

Gaining Custom Aptitudes

At levels 3, 5, 7, 9: choose new aptitudes

Custom Skill Aptitudes: Work with GM to create, follow guidelines in this document

Custom Inherent Aptitudes: Require GM approval and narrative justification: - With demihuman keyword: Can gain related Inherent Aptitudes - Through transformation: Gain

new keyword through major story event - Significant cost: Resources, time, quest, or permanent character change

Evolving Your Character

Keywords can change: - Gain new keywords through story (Exiled, Cursed, Chosen) - Keywords justify new aptitudes - Background keywords earned through play

Custom aptitudes can be created: - Work with GM at level-up - Base on character's experiences - Follow guidelines in this document - Iterate based on playtesting

Circles can be learned: - Must have one Circle to learn another - Each Circle = one aptitude choice - Maximum 6 total aptitudes - Can create custom Circles using this guide

Quick Reference

Aptitude Balance Quick Check

- ☐ Generally useful (not too narrow)
- ☐ Has limitations or costs (not always-on power)
- ☐ Fits clear theme (profession or species trait)
- ☐ Comparable to existing aptitudes
- ☐ Creates interesting decisions
- ☐ Would you be excited to play this?

Circle Balance Quick Check

- ☐ Clear theme (one sentence explanation)
- ☐ 8 diverse spells (combat, utility, unique)
- ☐ Base spells are useful and scalable
- ☐ Scaling is intuitive
- ☐ Comparable power to existing Circles
- ☐ Distinct from other Circles

Spell Creation Quick Reference

Base spell needs: - Effect (what it does) - Target/Area (1 target or 10 ft) - Range (30 ft or touch) - Duration (1 round or 1 turn)

Common enhancements: - +1d damage = +1 DC - +1 target = +1 DC - +1 round/turn = +1 DC - x2 area = +1 DC - +10 ft range = +1 DC - +1 size category = +2 DC

Final Thoughts

The beauty of Rath's customization system is its flexibility. You can:

- **Use everything as written** - The starter classes and preset Circles provide a complete, balanced game
- **Mix and match** - Combine existing aptitudes in new ways

- **Create selectively** - Make one custom aptitude or Circle while using the rest as written
- **Build from scratch** - Design completely unique characters and magic systems

The key is communication between players and GM. Custom content should enhance everyone's fun, not create balance problems or slow play.

When in doubt: - Compare to existing content - Start conservative and buff later if needed - Focus on what's fun and interesting - Remember that narrative justification matters more than mechanical perfection - Playtest and iterate

Remember: The best custom content: - Solves a specific problem ("I want to play X but can't with existing options") - Fits the game world and tone - Creates interesting stories - Makes everyone at the table happy

Now go forth and create amazing characters and magic!